

Parshas Emor. The Gemara in Yoma 69b discusses the historical moment when the members of the Sanhedrin davened for three days and three nights to destroy the יצר הרע for עבודה זרה. We also know the famous מעשה with מנשה מלך יהודה. People criticized him for being an עובד עבודה זרה, and he came in a dream and responded: "If you had been alive in my time, you would have picked up the hem of your garment and run faster than I did toward עבודה זרה."

So there was a tremendous יצר הרע for עבודה זרה. However, that Wile E. Coyote יצר הרע got smart and he substituted the יצר הרע for עבודה זרה for לשון הרע. We are all נכשל more or less in the עבירה of לשון הרע and its sidekick and buddy, רכילות. Rabbi Oelbaum discussed in his חומש שיעור many deep aspects of לשון הרע. He emphasized the importance of learning the הלכות of לשון הרע - the ספר הפז חיים and the many other ספרים on the topic that are available today. But he said something critical: the root of לשון הרע lies in a flaw in our מדות. And he quoted a חובות הלבבות to illustrate this point.

In פרק י the שער הכניעה, relates the following: They asked one of the חכמים, "What brought you to greatness? How did you become the leader and master of your generation?" He replied, "I never met a person in whom I didn't see some מעלה greater than my own. If he was smarter than me, I would say, 'He has more חכמה than I do.' If I was smarter than him, I would say, 'He has more שמים than I have.' If he was older than me, I would say, 'What a זכות, he has more מצוות than I do.' If he was younger than me, I would say, 'How fortunate he is, he has fewer עבירות than I have.'" This חכם was always able to see the positive and the מעלה in every single person he met. Rabbi Oelbaum also brought down from R' Elimelech of Lizhensk, which he said is actually a song, and the words are ותן בלבנו שנראה כל אחד מעלות חברינו ולא חסרונם. This brings us to a powerful story from the sefer פלאות התורה on אוצר פרשת אמור. The פרשה contains many הלכות about כהנים, and this particular story involves a כהן and highlights the importance of the מדה of seeing others' מעלות, even if they seem less capable or intelligent than us. Perhaps they are, in fact, far greater.

There was a gadol from about 200 years ago, the author of the לבושי שרד. The חתם סופר brings down a מעשה that in the place where the לבושי שרד was a rav, there was a פרנס, the head of the community, who was the wealthiest man around, but a tremendous הארץ עם. That happens all the time. The wealthiest man is not necessarily the smartest man. As we know, פרנסה comes from הקדוש ברוך הוא directly, not from our wily business instincts. He became the ראש of the קהל through his wealth, and he was a כהן. He was frequently fighting with his wife, constant arguments and bickering. The rav, the לבושי שרד, tried repeatedly to make שלום between them, but to no avail. The man would regularly come to the rav saying, "I want to give her a גט. I want to end this." The famous saying brought down here is חכם עדיף מנביא - A wise person, and in this particular case, we're talking about the aspect of שכל, can sometimes be better than a navi. The לבושי שרד said to the בעל, "You're right. You really should give her a גט. You should be מגרש her. But right now you can't. It's impossible. Why? Because you're a כהן and she is טמא. And since you have to hand her the גט, you can't give it to her because she's in טומאה. So hold off for a little while." And that he did. The הארץ עם accepted those words, and he went away. They eventually made up. Same thing happened again and again and again. Each time he would come to the rav to ask him to help him write a גט for his wife to be מגרש her, the rav would put him off and say that she's טמא and you can't do it because you're a כהן.

Later in his life, the לבושי שרד moved to ארץ ישראל and became a rav in צפת. Another person came in and took his place. I'll use the words that the אוצר פלאות התורה uses: רב אחר אשר חשב עצמו כחכם בעיניו ועז לאותו - He thought he was a genius, and that his predecessor was not that terribly smart. Soon enough, the עשיר came to the new rav saying, "I want to be מגרש my wife." The rav replied, "Okay", and sat him down to write him a גט. The עשיר asked him, "But how can you do that? It's impossible for me to be מגרש my wife because she's not טהור. She's טמא." This second rav, whoever he was, started to laugh and make ארץ ישראל in לבושי שרד. He performed the גירושין, and then wrote a long letter to the לבושי שרד.



to knock off - it was like a קינדערשפיל - all of the things that the לבושי שרד had said to this עשיר, to this פרנס, and to denigrate him, probably not in a בכבודיק way. The לבושי שרד received this letter, turned it over and wrote the following on the back: אל תהי שוטה, איזהו חכם הרואה את הנולד - Foolish man. Who is a חכם? Someone who can see ahead. And he sent back that letter.

Not too many days went by, and the רוגז of the עשיר dissipated and he wanted to marry his wife. He came to the rav and said, "I want to remarry my wife". The rav replied, "You can't. You're a כהן. A כהן cannot marry a גרושה." The עשיר became a bitter enemy of this rav, and he hounded him, so much so that the rav had to leave town. This happened because of his shortsightedness, his inability to see what would be the outcome of his actions. This is brought down in פרקי אבות: חכמים הזהירו בדבריכם: פרקי אבות - Think carefully what you do. You should not be מבזה or make fun of anyone, and you should certainly be very careful before an עם הארץ. Treat everyone with respect.

It's incumbent upon us to take the moral lesson from this story. It's a wise suggestion: Whenever you meet someone, assume they are at least as smart as you, if not smarter. It's a life lesson that will serve you well and pay great dividends.

(Incidentally, the first half of פרשת אמור on אוצר פלאות התורה is full of stories and fascinating halachic discussions about כהנים. One question it raises: Can a כהן go to the קבר of יוחאי בר יוחאי? It's a very interesting קשיא. We ourselves had this question when we were in ארץ ישראל just a few days ago. Another one: Can כהנים enter the מערת המכפלה? He brings down that the מנחת אלעזר, the Munkatcher Rebbe came out very strongly that כהנים should not go into the מערת המכפלה. And the famous Shiniver Rebbe, R' Yechezkel Shraga himself writes in these words, "The Torah tells us כהנים have to be careful that they should not become טמא. It's my חיוב to tell everybody that people are being מיקל and letting כהנים into קברי צדיקים. It's a big mistake. ואין להם על מה לסמוך להקל באיסור דאורייתא חס ושלום. So, the הלכות about כהנים are all clearly delineated in פרשת אמור, and the sefer has a large section on them. If you're a כהן, I think it'll be worth your while to sit down with this sefer and look through it, it's really quite enlightening.)

